HMICFRS

His Majesty's Inspectorate of Constabulary and Fire & Rescue Services

Fire & Rescue Service 2023–25

Effectiveness, efficiency and people

An inspection of London Fire Brigade

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Changes to this round of inspection

We last inspected London Fire Brigade in January 2022. And in July 2022, we published our inspection report with our findings on the brigade's effectiveness and efficiency and how well it looks after its people.

We followed this up with a re-inspection in January and August 2023 to specifically consider the cause of concern that was previously issued for preventing fires and other risks. We carried out a further re-inspection in February 2024 to specifically consider the cause of concern that was previously issued for promoting the right values and culture.

This inspection contains our third assessment of the brigade's effectiveness and efficiency, and how well it looks after its people. We have measured the brigade against the same 11 areas and given a grade for each.

We haven't given separate grades for effectiveness, efficiency and people as we did previously. This is to encourage the brigade to consider our inspection findings as a whole and not focus on just one area.

We now assess services against the characteristics of good performance, and we more clearly link our judgments to causes of concern and areas for improvement. We have also expanded our previous four-tier system of graded judgments to five. As a result, we can state more precisely where we consider improvement is needed and highlight good performance more effectively. However, these changes mean it isn't possible to make direct comparisons between grades awarded in this round of fire and rescue service inspections with those from previous years.

A reduction in grade, particularly from good to adequate, doesn't necessarily mean there has been a reduction in performance, unless we say so in the report.

This report sets out our inspection findings for London Fire Brigade.

More information on how we assess fire and rescue services and our graded judgments is available on our website.

Overall summary

Our judgments

Our inspection assessed how well London Fire Brigade has performed in 11 areas. We have made the following graded judgments:

Outstanding	Good	Adequate	Requires improvement	Inadequate
Responding to major incidents	Understanding fire and risk	Public safety through fire regulation	Managing performance and developing leaders	
	Preventing fire and risk	Promoting values and culture		
	Responding to fires and emergencies	Right people, right skills		
	Best use of resources	Promoting fairness and diversity		
	Future affordability			

In the rest of the report, we set out our detailed findings about the areas in which the brigade has performed well and where it should improve.

HMI summary

It was a pleasure to revisit London Fire Brigade. I am grateful for the positive and constructive way in which the brigade engaged with our inspection staff.

I am pleased to find significant improvements in the performance of London Fire Brigade since our January 2022 inspection.

It has improved its understanding of risk and other emergencies through its community risk management plan, 'Your London Fire Brigade', which it has communicated to the public. It also continues to respond quickly to fires, and we have graded it as outstanding in responding to major and multi-agency incidents.

In relation to keeping people safe and secure from fire and other risks, it is also performing well.

It still needs to improve in some areas to provide a consistently good service across the brigade. For example, it could improve how it identifies and develops high-potential staff and how it manages individual performance through performance and development reviews.

My principal findings from our assessments of the brigade over the past year are as follows:

- The brigade has significantly improved its ability to respond effectively to a marauding terrorist attack through investment in equipment and an extensive programme of training for firefighters.
- The brigade has a good system to prioritise its home fire safety visits so that those most at risk of fire or other emergencies are seen soonest.
- The brigade has a good understanding of how productive its firefighters are, by setting clear targets and using technology well to monitor this.
- The brigade is making good progress to improve culture, with well-defined values, which are understood, and a plan to improve services that support cultural change, such as human resources, that is progressing well.
- The brigade needs to make sure risk-based inspection programme work is appropriately prioritised by staff so that it can meet its targets.
- The brigade needs to do more to recruit a more diverse workforce and to improve how it uses positive action to do this.
- The brigade needs to make sure it continues to build staff trust and confidence in the processes it has to deal with poor behaviour.

Overall, I am pleased with the significant progress that the brigade has made since our last inspection. While there is still more to do, it is evident that the brigade understands where to make these further improvements and has achievable plans for them.



Lee Freeman

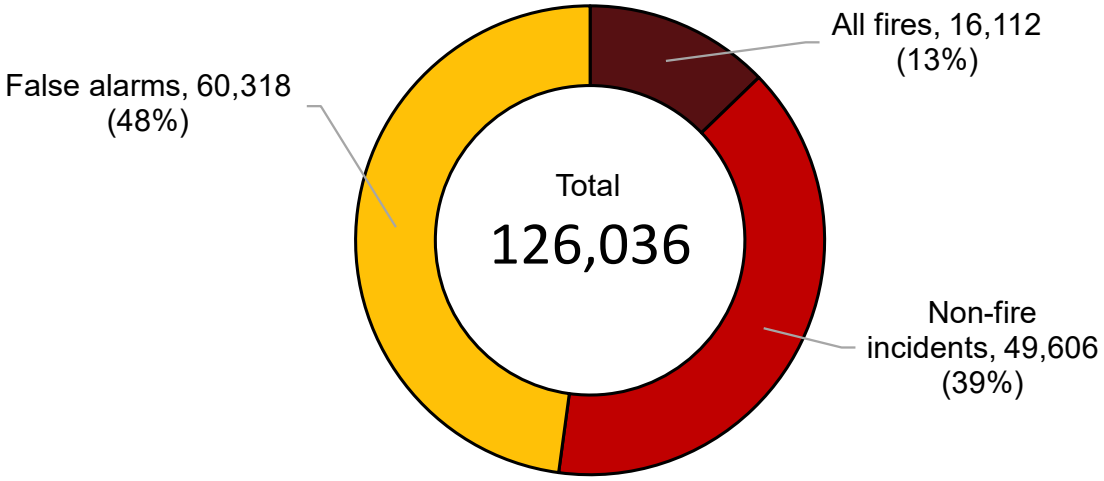
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Service in numbers

Profile	Greater London	England
Area Square miles	607	50,370
Population (thousands) 30 June 2022	8,866	57,106
Population density Thousands per square mile	14.6	1.1
Cost		
Funding Year ending 31 March 2023		£2.5bn
Expenditure per population Year ending 31 March 2023	£57.84	£46.66
Response		
Incidents attended per 1,000 population Year ending 31 December 2023	14.2	10.4
Home fire safety checks carried out by fire and rescue service per 1,000 population Year ending 31 March 2023	5.8	9.3
Fire safety audits per 100 known premises Year ending 31 March 2023	3.2	2.0
Availability of wholetime pumps Year ending 31 March 2023	85.1%	

London Fire Brigade doesn't use any on-call pumping engines.

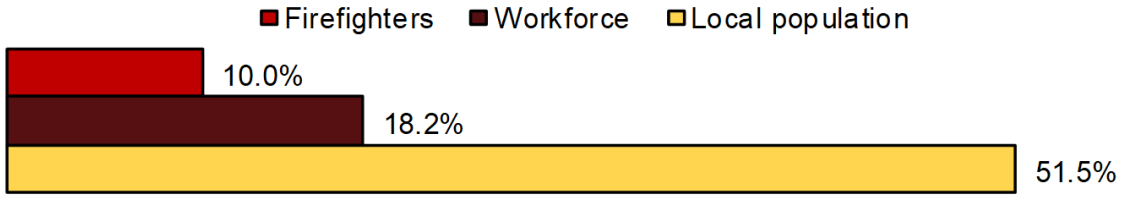
Incidents attended in year ending 31 December 2023



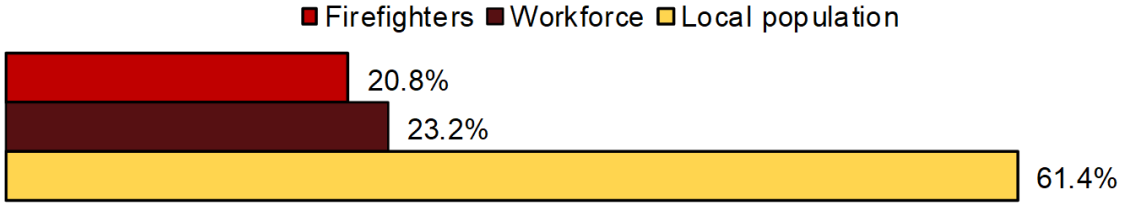
Workforce

	Greater London	England
Five-year change in total workforce 2018 to 2023	2.4%	1.4%
Number of firefighters per 1,000 population Year ending 31 March 2023	0.51	0.61
Percentage of firefighters who are wholetime Year ending 31 March 2023	100.0%	65.5%

Percentage of firefighters, workforce and population who identified as a woman as at 31 March 2023



Percentage of firefighters, workforce and population who were from ethnic minority backgrounds as at 31 March 2023



References to ethnic minorities in this report include people from White minority backgrounds but exclude people from Irish minority backgrounds. This is due to current data collection practices for national data. For more information on data and analysis in this report, please view the 'About the data' section of our website.

Understanding the risk of fire and other emergencies

Good

London Fire Brigade is good at understanding risk.

Each fire and rescue service should identify and assess all foreseeable fire and rescue-related risks that could affect its communities. It should use its protection and response capabilities to prevent or mitigate these risks for the public.

Promising practice

The brigade's community forum acts as a critical friend in how the brigade operates

The brigade has established a community forum with a wide range of people and organisations including Almanaar: The Muslim Cultural Heritage Centre, Grenfell Tower survivors, health and social care and bereaved family members.

This is in response to the brigade's independent review of culture, published in 2022, which underlined the need for the brigade to listen to London's communities. Forum members act as a critical friend to the brigade and support a culture of co-production and community involvement. The forum influences several areas, including:

- the brigade's new strategy and community risk management plan;
- the equality impact assessment panel; and
- borough commander and senior management selection processes.

Collaboration with engineers improves the brigade's ability to identify structural hazards

The brigade works with Collaborative Reporting for Safer Structures (CROSS) to increase its awareness of structural hazards.

Following the Grenfell Tower fire, Dame Judith Hackitt identified that CROSS applied only to structural engineers and that representation of fire and rescue services was needed to match that of structural engineers. Now, the brigade and the National Fire Chiefs Council's emerging hazards group are CROSS's sole partners in the fire and rescue service sector.

One of the ways this has improved the brigade's service to the public is that CROSS reporting identified the hazard posed by reinforced autoclaved aerated concrete. As a result, the brigade included this in its processes, so crews know what to look for during prevention visits and operations.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

The brigade is good at identifying risk

The brigade has assessed a suitable range of risks and threats using a thorough community risk management planning process. In its assessment of risk, it uses information it has collected from a broad range of internal and external sources and datasets. It uses historical incident data, demographic data and national security risk assessment data to identify current and future risk. For example, these risks include day-to-day risks (such as fires in homes), extraordinary risks (such as pandemics) and emerging risks (such as climate change).

When appropriate, the brigade has consulted and held constructive dialogue with its communities and other relevant parties to understand risk and explain how it intends to mitigate it. For example, the brigade held 200 community events as part of its consultation process for its community risk management plan (CRMP), 'Your London Fire Brigade'.

The brigade used previous CRMP consultation data to identify gaps in responses from groups such as people with disabilities and minority communities. The brigade's community engagement team then spoke directly to these groups. These included the East London Mosque and the deaf community (through DeafPLUS).

The brigade has an effective CRMP

In our 2022 inspection we identified two areas for improvement:

- The brigade should update and publish its integrated risk management plan (IRMP), the London Safety Plan (LSP), so it can outline to the public current and future risks and how the brigade will mitigate them.
- The brigade should make sure that the aims and objectives of prevention, protection and response activity are clearly outlined in its IRMP, the LSP.

We found significant progress has been made, and both these areas for improvement are now closed.

Following the brigade's assessment of risk, its IRMP, the LSP, has been replaced by a detailed CRMP. This is called 'Your London Fire Brigade'. This sets out the brigade's purpose and vision: 'Trusted to serve and protect London'. It clearly describes how the brigade intends to use its prevention, protection and response activities to mitigate or reduce the risks and threats the community faces both now and in the future.

The plan describes four areas where the brigade is focusing its work and eight commitments it is making to residents and businesses. We found these were clearly connected to departmental strategies, and borough and local station plans. Thirty-one key performance indicators are used to track progress against the commitments.

The brigade gathers, maintains and shares risk information in a challenging operational area

The brigade's operational area holds a significant amount of the risk associated with the UK's people, premises and places. The brigade told us that London has around 20,000 listed buildings, over 300 hospitals and a large proportion of England's high-rise premises. At the time of our inspection, there were 6,285 high-risk residential premises registered on the brigade's high-rise portal by the people who are responsible for them.

The brigade routinely collects and updates the information it has about the highest-risk people, places and threats it has identified. This includes operational risk information about high-risk premises. We found good processes and guidance in place to help crews gather this information.

Brigade figures show that, as of July 2024, 53,582 premises risk assessments were held on its operational risk database. Due to their level of risk, 11,461 of these require a physical visit by crews. Some staff told us that completing the programme of risk visits was challenging. We don't underestimate the scale of the work needed to maintain these visits.

We sampled a broad range of the risk information the brigade collects, including:

- high-risk, high-rise buildings;
- short-term and temporary risk information;
- site-specific risk information held on the brigade's operational risk database; and
- protection files.

This information is readily available to the brigade's prevention, protection and response staff. This means these teams can identify, reduce and mitigate risk effectively. For example, operational staff can access important high-rise information, such as evacuation strategies, on the brigade's high-rise portal. Urgent and risk-critical information is emailed out through operational newsflashes.

The brigade acknowledges that it has yet to introduce an IT system that holds brigade risk information in one place. The brigade still plans to carry out this work.

A few premises risk files held on the brigade's operational risk database that we sampled had errors. For example, the frequency of visits to a high-risk premises didn't match the risk score. The brigade acknowledged this, carried out further checks and reminded staff of their quality assurance responsibilities. The brigade should make sure quality assurance processes are consistently maintained.

Where appropriate, the brigade shares risk information with other organisations. The brigade is a member of the blue light collaboration group in London. Relevant information is shared in this group to maintain an effective emergency response.

Staff at the locations we visited, including firefighters and fire control staff, were able to show us that they could access, use and share risk information quickly to help them resolve incidents safely.

The brigade learns from operational activity

The brigade records and communicates risk information effectively. It also routinely updates risk assessments and uses feedback from local and national operational activities to inform its planning assumptions.

For example, following a fatal lithium-ion battery fire, the brigade targeted e-bike riders through its #ChargeSafe safety campaign. We also found that learning identified after an electric bus fire led to Transport for London (TfL) installing first responder stickers on all buses. This helps crews identify if the bus is fully electric, hybrid or diesel.

Preventing fires and other risks

Good

London Fire Brigade is good at preventing fires and other risks.

Fire and rescue services must promote fire safety, including giving fire safety advice. To identify people at greatest risk from fire, services should work closely with other organisations in the public and voluntary sectors, and with the police and ambulance services. They should share intelligence and risk information with these other organisations when they identify vulnerability or exploitation.

Promising practice

The #ChargeSafe campaign communicates key safety advice to prevent e-bike and e-scooter fires

The brigade has developed the #ChargeSafe campaign because of an emerging trend in e-bike and e-scooter fires.

These battery-powered items have increased in popularity. Correspondingly, so did the number of fires the brigade attended that were caused by batteries combusting.

The brigade acted promptly to start the #ChargeSafe campaign and get safety messages out to the community. It has since developed a suite of materials that can be used by all staff and partners to raise awareness of key safety advice.

Also as part of the campaign, the brigade has worked with Transport for London to reduce the risk from e-mobility products. Transport for London has introduced risk-based bans on e-scooters and e-bikes on key parts of the network.
The brigade has also produced guidance documents for people responsible for high-rise premises. And it has run workshops about e-bike safety with staff from large delivery companies.

The Havering hoarding team works in partnership to make vulnerable adults safer in their homes

Firefighters set up the Havering hoarding team in February 2023 due to a lack of joint working between multi-agency professionals and the brigade in relation to hoarding and vulnerable adults.

As part of the project, the team initiated joint visits with social services, housing and care staff, and NHS community nurses.

The project started with 37 hoarders known to the brigade. The team has since carried out 413 home fire safety visits to 185 households in Havering that are very high risk or vulnerable.

The team has also successfully created a workshop and presented it to over 300 staff from other organisations to make them aware of how to refer to the brigade and identify risks when visiting people's homes.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

The prevention strategy is linked to risk

The brigade's prevention strategy is clearly linked to the risks it has identified in its CRMP. This strategy is supported by a prevention delivery plan, which is linked to borough and local station plans. For example, the CRMP identifies certain physical vulnerabilities that can put people at greater risk. The brigade told us the community risk plan for Lewisham identified a large community of people with a hearing impairment. As a result, crews in the area are being trained to understand British Sign Language.

The brigade's teams work well together and with other relevant organisations on prevention, and they share relevant information when needed. The brigade works with organisations such as TfL on its 'Vision Zero' work to end death or serious injury on the TfL network by 2041.

The brigade uses information to adjust its planning assumptions and direct activity between its prevention, protection and response functions. It reviews the assessment of risk annually so it can respond to any changes in risk.

Those most at risk are seen soonest

The brigade uses a risk-based approach to clearly prioritise its prevention activity towards people most at risk from fire and other emergencies.

The brigade has an automated system which assesses an individual's vulnerability, for example, based on whether they smoke, have a disability or live alone. This identifies who needs a home fire safety visit (HFSV) soonest.

We were impressed to find the brigade responds to very high-risk HFSVs within four hours of referral. It completes high-risk HFSVs within 7 days and medium-risk HFSVs within 28 days. It directs low-risk individuals to its online HFSV checker. Fire control staff are trained to take HFSV referrals out of hours.

The number of completed HFSVs is increasing. Between 1 April 2022 and 31 March 2023, the brigade carried out 51,064 HFSVs compared to 37,075 in the previous year. This is an increase of 13,989 HFSVs.

The brigade has set itself a target of completing 60 percent of its total HFSVs on high-risk individuals, such as those who are elderly or have mobility issues. At the time of our inspection, brigade figures showed that 56.65 percent of all HFSVs were completed on high-risk individuals.

The brigade recognises that the high-risk category is too broad and includes some people who aren't high risk. The brigade is taking steps to refine this process.

We found some examples of the brigade targeting high-rise properties for HFSVs. However not all staff we spoke to could recall carrying out this work.

We were surprised to find that the electronic HFSV system wasn't being used across the brigade. The brigade told us that there were connectivity issues with the electronic tablets, which are being fixed.

The brigade uses a broad range of information and data to target its prevention activity at vulnerable individuals and groups. For example, borough commanders use demographic data, information from fire statistics and fatal fire reviews to amend their borough plans to focus on risk areas.

The brigade carries out a range of interventions, which it adapts to the level of risk in its communities. For example, we saw a report of a fatal fire caused by a lithium-ion battery in a house in multiple occupation. The brigade runs the #ChargeSafe campaign across London in response to events such as this to promote e-bike and e-scooter safety.

Quality assurance of HFSVs has improved

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it quality assures its prevention activity, so that staff carry out HFSVs to an appropriate standard. We are satisfied with the progress made and so the area for improvement is closed.

We found that prevention managers sample a set number of files monthly to quality assure them. On referrals, managers check the initial risk score to make sure it matches the vulnerabilities recorded during the visit. Station commanders go out annually to quality assure completion of HFSVs by crews.

We reviewed a sample of completed HFSV files. Most files we inspected were completed to a good level of quality and showed that the brigade met the time it sets itself to complete the HFSV. The files we saw that were yet to be allocated for completion were well managed.

A few files we reviewed lacked detail about advice given during an HFSV or whether safeguarding referrals had been made. The brigade has developed a framework that will improve the consistency of quality assurance.

HFSV training is made available to staff

Staff told us they have the right skills and are confident to carry out HFSVs. These visits cover an appropriate range of hazards that can put vulnerable people at greater risk from fire and other emergencies. The visits include fitting smoke alarms and giving advice on fire safety in the home.

The brigade makes training available for staff. Nearly all staff we spoke to said they have had training in HFSVs. At the time of our inspection, brigade figures showed the overall completion rate for the brigade's newly updated HFSV training was 68 percent. The brigade should make sure all staff who carry out HFSVs complete this updated training.

More staff are trained in safeguarding

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure safeguarding training is carried out by all staff. We are satisfied with the progress made in this area and so the area for improvement is closed.

Safeguarding e-learning is available to all staff. Trainee firefighters get face-to-face safeguarding training as part of their training programme. Borough commanders attend workshops on safeguarding responsibilities and processes.

Brigade figures show that, as of July 2024, 76 percent (4,331 out of 5,715) of all staff had completed safeguarding training. For station-based staff, this increased to 88 percent (3,669 out of 4,179).

Some staff we spoke to said they would benefit from more safeguarding training specific to their level of responsibility. The brigade had plans in place to improve safeguarding training and meet the National Fire Chiefs Council's safeguarding competency framework by autumn 2024.

Staff we interviewed told us about occasions when they had identified safeguarding problems. Nearly all told us they feel confident and trained to act appropriately and promptly. For example, after one incident a crew didn't leave until they could collect and fit an arson-proof letterbox to safeguard the family.

Communication of prevention information has improved

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should improve its use of communications to provide fire prevention information and to promote community safety. The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We found the brigade follows national and local prevention campaigns to inform its communications. These include national campaigns, such as road and boat safety weeks, and local water safety campaigns, which are run with the Royal National Lifeboat Institution (RNLI) and the coastguard.

The brigade's community engagement team works with the communications team to make sure that messages are tailored appropriately for communities and hard-to-reach groups they work with.

The brigade works well with others to prevent fires and other risks

The brigade works with a wide range of other organisations to prevent fires and other emergencies. These include TfL, Samaritans, the RNLI and the Office for Product Safety and Standards. For example, the brigade shares fire incident data with the Office for Product Safety and Standards to better inform safety work in areas such as e-bikes and large domestic appliances. And the brigade continues to work with volunteers who run its fire cadets programme across all 32 boroughs and the City of London.

We found good evidence that the brigade routinely refers people at greatest risk to organisations that may better meet their needs. These include social care teams and child and adolescent mental health services. For the year 2022/23, the brigade made 2,199 referrals to other agencies where further support needs were identified following an HFSV.

Arrangements are also in place to receive referrals from others, such as the London Ambulance Service and suppliers of oxygen used by people in their homes. In the year ending 31 March 2023, the brigade received 4,191 referrals from other agencies for an HFSV. The brigade acts appropriately on the referrals it receives.

The brigade routinely exchanges information with other public sector organisations about people and groups at greatest risk. It uses this information to challenge planning assumptions and target prevention activity. For example, the brigade has developed a workshop so staff from other organisations know how to make referrals to the brigade and identify risks such as hoarding when visiting people's homes.

The brigade works effectively to tackle fire-setting behaviour

The brigade has a range of suitable and effective interventions to target and educate people with different needs who show signs of fire-setting behaviour. The brigade has a dedicated, well-trained fire-setters team that works with the highest-risk individuals who display fire-setting behaviour. The brigade told us that the team received 124 referrals in the year 2023/24. As of March 2024, 68 cases were completed. The team does 6 and 12-month follow-ups to check that fire-setting behaviours haven't continued. The brigade told us that in all cases the fire-setting behaviour had stopped.

The brigade has improved its evaluation of prevention work

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should better evaluate its prevention work, so it fully understands how effective it is at reducing the risk of fire and other emergencies. The brigade has made sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were encouraged to find the brigade was evaluating some of its work to measure how effective its activity is and to make sure all sections of its communities get appropriate access to prevention services that meet their needs. For example, it evaluates work with fire-setters to understand how effective this work is at stopping fire-setting behaviour. And it carries out community polling twice a year to check if prevention messages are being understood.

The brigade has produced evaluation guidance for staff and an evaluation tool. However, at the time of our inspection the tool wasn't in full use across the brigade so we couldn't tell how effective this is.

Prevention activities take account of feedback from the public, other organisations and other parts of the brigade. For example, a selection of people who have had an HFSV are called to get feedback about the visit. The brigade uses feedback to inform its planning assumptions and change future activity, so it focuses on what the community needs and what works.

Protecting the public through fire regulation

Adequate

London Fire Brigade is adequate at protecting the public through fire regulation.

All fire and rescue services should assess fire risks in certain buildings and, when necessary, require building owners to comply with fire safety legislation. Each service decides how many assessments it does each year. But it must have a locally determined, risk-based inspection programme for enforcing the legislation.

Areas for improvement

The brigade should make sure its staff appropriately prioritise risk-based inspection programme work.

The brigade should make sure it responds in time to building regulation consultations.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

Protection risks are linked to brigade plans

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should develop a protection strategy that shows how protection resource will be used to protect the public from fire, both now and in the future. The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were pleased to find the brigade has developed a protection strategy that is clearly linked to the risks identified in its CRMP.

Staff across the brigade are involved in this activity, effectively exchanging information as needed. For example, the brigade makes sure information on high-rise buildings is available to staff through its high-rise portal. And information about oxygen users

or hoarding is made available to crews through the brigade's mobilising system. The brigade then uses information to adjust planning assumptions and direct activity between its protection, prevention and response functions. This means resources are properly aligned to risk.

The brigade operates in a high-risk environment

The brigade operates in an area that has a substantial concentration of high-risk premises. For example, Home Office data for the year ending 31 March 2022 shows that, out of 217,105 known premises, 49.16 percent (106,733) were identified as high risk. For the year ending 31 March 2023, out of 224,790 known premises, 64.69 percent (145,426) were identified as high risk.

Resource is aligned to the highest-risk premises

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it allocates enough resources to a prioritised risk-based inspection programme (RBIP). We are satisfied with the progress made and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has allocated the resources it has to the greatest risks identified in its CRMP. For example, a high-rise premises team focuses on inspection activity at high-rise premises. A heritage team focuses on fire safety in heritage buildings.

The brigade told us that, with dedicated teams doing this work, area-based teams can focus on the updated RBIP. Premises go through a scoring process to determine their level of risk and how often they are audited.

The brigade has worked with the National Fire Chiefs Council to put a process in place for changing the risk level of a premises. Inspecting officers can increase or decrease the risk level based on how good fire safety measures are.

While the RBIP identifies the highest-risk premises, the brigade told us that fire deaths can also occur in lower-risk premises, such as shops or converted dwellings. One example was an illegally converted office block that had 40 people living in it.

The brigade needs to appropriately prioritise risk-based inspection work

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it puts in place measures so it can meet its planned schedule of fire safety audits. We are satisfied with the progress made and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has increased the number of competent protection staff. In the year ending 31 March 2023, the brigade had a total of 123 competent protection staff. This is an increase of 31 from the year ending 31 March 2022.

We found the brigade has used a range of methods and incentives to increase the competency levels of protection staff. For example, the brigade set up its own fire

safety training academy to train more people and introduced higher pay for protection officers depending on their level of qualification. The brigade told us that because of this work it has seen competency levels increase in fire safety teams responsible for RBIP work.

Area protection teams are given a guide to help them prioritise their work. The brigade told us that it expects 30 to 40 percent of inspection officer time to be spent on RBIP work. However, we found that teams aren't always prioritising RBIP work. One team told us that licensing requests and complaints from crews were prioritised and that it spent 10 to 15 percent of its time on the RBIP. Another team told us planning for large events and responding to complaints from the public were prioritised and RBIP work is done in any time left over.

The brigade isn't consistently auditing the buildings it has targeted in the timescales it has set. For example, we viewed one file, for a hospital, which had no record of an audit being carried out since 2017.

RBIP targets are in place, but the brigade isn't meeting them

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade needs to be able to measure how it is meeting the targets set out in its RBIP to be assured it is effectively protecting the public from fires. The brigade has made satisfactory progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has set itself a target of completing 60 percent of its total inspections on high-risk premises. However, the brigade's performance report for April 2024 shows 38.86 percent of inspections were on high-risk premises. The brigade recognises it doesn't have enough competent and qualified staff to meet its target. So it is reducing the target from 60 percent to 40 percent.

Despite an increase in competent protection staff, the brigade still doesn't have enough qualified protection staff to support its inspection and enforcement activity. In the year ending 31 March 2023, the brigade carried out inspections on 2.3 percent (3,390 out of 145,426) of known high-risk premises. In the year ending 31 March 2022, the brigade carried out inspections on 5.5 percent (5,894 out of 106,733) of known high-risk premises.

Most fire safety audits are completed to a good standard

We reviewed a range of audits that the brigade had carried out at different buildings across its area. These included audits carried out:

- as part of the brigade's risk-based inspection programme;
- after fires at premises where fire safety legislation applies;
- after enforcement action had been taken; or
- at high-rise, high-risk buildings.

Nearly all audits we reviewed were completed in a consistent, systematic way and in line with the brigade's policies. A few weren't. For example, some post-fire incident records we sampled were incomplete. The brigade should make sure the quality of its fire safety audits is consistent.

The brigade makes relevant information from its audits available to operational teams and fire control staff.

Quality assurance is good

The brigade carries out proportionate quality assurance of its protection activity. Among the files we sampled, we found examples of quality assurance taking place.

Quality assurance is carried out by protection team leaders and the brigade's quality assurance team. Feedback following quality assurance checks is given to protection staff by email or in a face-to-face meeting.

The brigade takes enforcement action where appropriate

The brigade consistently uses its full range of enforcement powers, and when appropriate, it prosecutes those who don't comply with fire safety regulations. The brigade has an enforcement team with investigators and legal support. At the time of our inspection there were 19 cases being investigated.

In the year ending 31 March 2023, the brigade issued 96 alteration notices, 1,238 informal notifications, 206 enforcement notices and 118 prohibition notices. It carried out one prosecution.

The brigade completed eight prosecutions in the five years from 1 April 2018 to 31 March 2023. For example, in 2023 the brigade prosecuted Camden Council. The council pleaded guilty and was ordered to pay a £500,000 fine and £41,100 in court costs plus a victim surcharge.

The brigade is meeting the current demands of new fire safety legislation

Since our last inspection, the Building Safety Act 2022 and the Fire Safety (England) Regulations 2022 have been introduced to bring about better regulation and management of tall buildings.

The brigade is supporting the introduction of the Building Safety Regulator. The brigade has seconded 4.5 full-time equivalent posts to do this work. It expects these arrangements to have a manageable impact on its other protection activity. The brigade acknowledges that it doesn't have the resource to manage any further increase in work in this area without it negatively affecting other protection work. This is due to a shortage of competent protection staff.

The Fire Safety (England) Regulations 2022 introduced a range of duties for the managers of tall buildings. These include a requirement to give the fire and rescue service floor plans and inform them of any substantial faults to essential firefighting equipment, such as firefighting lifts.

We found the brigade has good arrangements in place to receive this information. These include a dedicated mailbox and high-rise portal where this information can be submitted and updated by managers of tall buildings. When the brigade doesn't receive the right information, it takes action. And it updates the risk information it gives its operational staff accordingly.

The brigade works well with other enforcement agencies

The brigade works closely with other enforcement agencies to regulate fire safety and it routinely exchanges risk information with them. These include local councils and the Care Quality Commission. For example, the brigade worked with a local council when a prohibition notice was required due to sleeping risks in an unlicensed house in multiple occupation. It was decided that it would be most effective if the council issued the notice to make sure the public were safe.

The brigade has made some improvement in its response to consultation requests

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it responds in time to building regulation consultations. The brigade has made some progress, but the area for improvement remains.

In the year ending 31 March 2023, the brigade completed 79.7 percent (8,109 out of 10,174) of all building regulation consultations in the required time frame. This is an improvement on the previous year in which the brigade responded to 61.2 percent (5,280 out of 8,626) in the required time frame. This means the brigade is in a better position to comment on fire safety arrangements at new and altered buildings.

The brigade continues to take steps to improve its response to building consultations. Since early 2024 all building consultations for London are being managed in one place by a new central team, as opposed to separate area teams. The brigade told us that this central team is now completing 95 percent of consultations within the time frames set. The brigade's fire engineering group completes more complex consultations. We look forward to seeing how this work progresses.

In the year ending 31 March 2023, the brigade completed 63.7 percent (1,322 out of 2,075) of licensing consultations in the required time frame. This is lower than the previous year in which the brigade responded to 84.5 percent (2,359 out of 2,793) in the required time frame.

The brigade acknowledges that a lack of qualified and competent staff affects the time taken to respond to consultations. This means that where a consultation, such as licensing, involves limited risk, the response may not be prioritised over those involving greater risk.

The brigade works well with businesses

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it works with local businesses and large organisations to share information and expectations about compliance with fire safety regulations. The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were pleased to find the brigade has a business engagement officer who works with local businesses and other organisations to promote compliance with fire safety legislation. Examples of this work include seminars with businesses and care homes about compliance.

The brigade has a section on its website for business owners, which provides relevant information on areas such as fire doors.

At the time of our inspection the brigade had 27 active primary authority partners, which include Asda and BT.

The brigade will attend fewer unwanted fire signals

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it effectively addresses the burden of false alarms. We are satisfied with the progress made and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade acknowledges that it has been attending too many false alarms, which isn't a good use of its resource. For the year 2022/23, 22.6 percent (47,691 out of 210,623) of emergency calls to the brigade were automated fire alarms (AFAs). Of these, only 4.3 percent weren't attended. In 2022/23, the average percentage of AFAs not attended for England was 38.0 percent.

From 29 October 2024, the brigade has changed its response to AFAs based on risk. It won't be attending AFAs between 7am and 8.30pm in commercial properties unless it also receives a call from a person reporting a fire. This will mean the number of AFAs it responds to will significantly decrease. There are some exemptions to this, which include schools, nurseries, care homes and heritage sites.

The brigade should continue its work with businesses to educate them about preventing false alarms occurring. Fewer unwanted calls mean fire engines are available to respond to a genuine incident rather than responding to a false one. It also reduces the risk to the public if fewer fire engines travel at high speed on the roads.

Responding to fires and other emergencies

Good

London Fire Brigade is good at responding to fires and other emergencies.

Fire and rescue services must be able to respond to a range of incidents such as fires, road traffic collisions and other emergencies in their areas.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

The brigade's response commitments are linked to risk

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure its response strategy provides the most appropriate response for the public in line with its integrated risk management plan (which is now known as a CRMP). The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were encouraged to find the brigade's response strategy is linked to the risks it has identified in its CRMP. Its fire engines and response staff, as well as its working patterns, are designed and located to help the brigade respond flexibly to fires and other emergencies with the appropriate resources.

For example, the brigade has made a clear commitment to maintain current levels of staff and fire engines to provide the speed and level of response required in London due to the high level of risk. It has also committed to keeping response times consistent by setting a single attendance time target across London.

Response to fires is fast

There are no national response standards of performance for the public. But the brigade has set out its own response standards in its CRMP, which are:

- first fire engine to an incident anywhere in London in an average time of six minutes;

- second fire engine to an incident anywhere in London in an average time of eight minutes;
- a fire engine anywhere in London within 10 minutes 90 percent of the time; and
- a fire engine anywhere in London within 12 minutes 95 percent of the time.

The brigade's 2024 performance report shows that it is achieving an average first engine response time of 5 minutes and 20 seconds. We were impressed to see that the time taken from receiving a call about a fire at Forest Gate police station on 6 March 2024 to the arrival of the first fire engine was 4 minutes.

The brigade consistently meets its standards. Home Office data shows that in the year ending 31 March 2024, the brigade's response time to primary fires was 6 minutes and 45 seconds. This is faster than the average for predominantly urban services.

Availability targets are challenging

To support its response strategy, the brigade sets itself a challenging target of having 100 percent of its 142 fire engines available 100 percent of the time. All the brigade's 102 fire stations are crewed by wholetime staff.

However, despite maintaining high availability, the brigade doesn't always meet this standard. For the year ending 31 March 2023, the overall availability for the brigade was 85.1 percent.

Incident commanders are trained to command incidents safely

The brigade has trained incident commanders, who are assessed regularly and properly. It aims to formally assess their skills every two years. It achieves this aim most of the time. We found during our inspection it had assessed:

- 96.5 percent (1,229 out of 1,274) of level 1 commanders;
- 93.4 percent (169 out of 181) of level 2 commanders;
- 100 percent (20 out of 20) of level 3 commanders; and
- 100 percent (9 out of 9) of level 4 commanders.

This helps the brigade safely, assertively and effectively manage the whole range of incidents it could face, from small and routine ones to complex multi-agency incidents.

As part of our inspection, we interviewed incident commanders from across the brigade. They were familiar with risk assessing, decision-making and recording information at incidents in line with national best practice, as well as the Joint Emergency Services Interoperability Principles.

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure staff accurately record risk assessments and control measures implemented at an incident, to alert commanders to workplace risks and help put safety control measures in place at the incident ground. We are satisfied the brigade is making sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has policy and guidance in place that clearly set out expectations about the recording of risk assessments at the scene of an incident. Station commanders complete more detailed risk assessments at larger incidents. The brigade should continue to make sure that incident commanders accurately record risk assessments in line with brigade policy.

Good progress implementing national operational guidance

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it puts in place and carries out a plan to adopt national operational guidance (NOG). The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were pleased to find robust plans in place to implement NOG. The plans are supported by a team that includes a project manager and five other people. The Mayor of London has invested £1.2 million in the design of an electronic hub where NOG-aligned policy and guidance will be available.

The brigade is making progress to incorporate NOG processes into training. For example, incident commanders are independently assessed through performance reviews of incidents they command. These reviews are completed using NOG guidance.

Fire control staff are included in response activity

We were pleased to see the brigade's fire control staff integrated into response activity such as its command, training, exercise, debrief and assurance activity. We found control staff were invited to debriefs following significant incidents. Most, but not all, control staff we spoke to said they were involved in brigade exercises. These included exercises to test response to marauding terrorist attacks (MTAs).

Firefighters have good access to risk information

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure its operational staff have good access to relevant and up-to-date cross-border risk information. The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

Firefighters have access to a range of risk information, which they can access electronically through mobile data terminals. This includes cross-border risk information and information held on the brigade's operational risk database and high-rise portal.

We sampled a range of risk information, including the information in place for firefighters responding to incidents at high-risk, high-rise buildings and the information held by fire control.

Most of the information we reviewed was up to date and detailed. Staff could easily access and understand it. Encouragingly, it had been completed with input from the brigade's prevention, protection and response functions when appropriate.

However, we found some information wasn't recorded accurately. We reported this to the brigade, which acted. It did further quality assurance work and reminded operational managers of their responsibilities in quality-checking risk information recorded by crews.

The operational debrief process has improved

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure its system for learning from operational debriefs is effective and that staff understand how to record learning from operational incidents.
The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has a comprehensive debrief policy in place. This gives clear guidance to staff on how to carry out debriefs and record learning following incidents. Hot debriefs are expected to be carried out following an incident or training event. Structured debriefs are more detailed and occur following an incident that could have had a risk-critical impact or where there is learning that needs further investigation.

We reviewed a range of emergency incidents and training events. These included major incidents, such as fires at commercial premises and an electric bus fire.
We found nearly all the debrief files to be detailed. However, a few files were missing information. For example, one file didn't have a record of the risk assessments that should take place at the scene of an incident. The brigade should make sure that information required for debriefs is consistently recorded.

Some learning from incidents that took place before our inspection had yet to be shared. For example, a fire at Forest Gate police station happened on 6 March 2024. The structured debrief took place on the 18 June 2024. At the time of our inspection learning from this incident had yet to be shared.

The brigade uses a prioritisation matrix to decide how quickly learning should be shared based on how critical it is. And it has made improvements to how soon important learning is communicated to staff. It has recently introduced operational newsflashes to make sure that critical learning is shared more quickly. For example, we saw an operational newsflash sent on 28 June 2024 relating to identification of bus fuel types following an electric bus fire. The brigade monitors operational newsflashes to make sure staff have read them.

The brigade has responded to learning from incidents to improve its service to the public. For example, following a rescue of a person from a trench, the brigade found it had no policy for this type of rescue and so put one in place.

We were encouraged to see the brigade is sharing its learning with other fire and rescue services, and acting on learning from them or operational learning from emergency service partners. This includes a number of incidents involving cannabis factories that the brigade responded to. Feedback led to a review of training in illicit drug facilities for hazardous material officers and operational staff. This was submitted for both national operational learning and joint organisational learning.

The brigade communicates incident information to the public well

The brigade has good systems in place to inform the public about ongoing incidents and help keep them safe during and after incidents. It is part of the London communication group, which warns and informs the public about major incidents.

The brigade uses press outlets and social media to inform the public about ongoing incidents. For example, it communicated through social media about a fire in Dagenham and the spread of smoke in the area.

Responding to major and multi-agency incidents

Outstanding

London Fire Brigade is outstanding at responding to major and multi-agency incidents.

All fire and rescue services must be able to respond effectively to multi-agency and cross-border incidents. This means working with other fire and rescue services (known as intraoperability) and emergency services (known as interoperability).

Promising practice

The brigade plays an extensive role in counterterrorism

The brigade plays a significant role in counterterrorism, not only across London but also across the rest of the UK and internationally.

The brigade has led on the design and implementation of the first fire and rescue service counterterrorism strategy to support implementation of all aspects of the CONTEST strategy. CONTEST is a UK Government-commissioned publication that sets out the UK's strategy to counter terrorism.

The brigade has also provided assistance through the Counter Terrorism Policing Headquarters to progress the UK's Joint Overseas Protect and Prepare procedures. And it has supported the development of the National Inter-agency Liaison Officer programme for overseas partners, including NATO.

Investment in technology has improved rescue and evacuation information for firefighters

Using a tablet to gather information, the brigade's fire survival guidance app allows information to be exchanged between fire control and the scene of an incident. It enables firefighters at the bridgehead (the position where firefighters are carrying out firefighting operations) to see real-time evacuation and fire survival guidance information. This helps them to carry out rescues and receive updates on a changing situation.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

The brigade is well prepared to respond to major incidents

The brigade has effectively anticipated and considered the reasonably foreseeable risks and threats it may face. These risks are listed in both local and national risk registers as part of its community risk management planning, for example:

- geopolitical risk (terrorism)
- industrial action (by brigade staff)
- urban wildfires
- urban flooding
- alternative fuels (used for transport).

The brigade tests its capability against areas of risk. For example, key sites such as airports have daily communication tests with fire control. And the brigade holds weekly resource forecasting meetings where intelligence and MTA response are discussed.

It is also familiar with the significant risks neighbouring fire and rescue services may face, and which it might reasonably be asked to respond to in an emergency. Firefighters have access to risk information from neighbouring services.

The brigade's ability to respond to MTA incidents is impressive

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure all frontline staff, and not just specialist response teams, are well protected and well prepared for being part of a multi-agency response to a community risk identified by the local resilience forum, including an MTA. It should make sure that all staff understand its procedures for responding to terrorist incidents. The brigade has made significant progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were pleased to find that the brigade has a robust policy and procedures in place to respond to MTA incidents. And it has invested in an extensive programme of training and equipment for firefighters to respond effectively. This includes the supply of 790 ballistic armour vests and 170 rescue stretchers. Firefighters and fire control staff we spoke to were trained and understood their role in an MTA incident.

The brigade told us that it has specialist MTA responders on all its fire engines. This means 354 MTA firefighters and officers are able to respond to an incident day or night. Additionally, the brigade can support national MTA response through its special entry and recovery team. This team can be deployed to terrorist incidents where fire is a threat.

We spoke to partners including Brent Council and British Transport Police. They told us they were confident that the brigade is well prepared to respond to an MTA incident.

The brigade tests its arrangements through exercises. For example, it held an MTA exercise at a disused hospital with police, ambulance and hazardous area response teams. Staff used rescue stretchers and ballistic armour vests.

Robust systems are in place to manage fire survival calls for a major incident

In our 2022 inspection, we focused on how the brigade had collected risk information and responded to the UK Government's building risk review programme for tall buildings.

In this inspection, we have focused on how well prepared the brigade is to respond to a major incident at a tall building, such as the tragedy at Grenfell Tower.

We found the brigade has well-developed policies and procedures in place for safely managing this type of incident. The brigade told us it has completed all 29 recommendations from the Grenfell Tower Inquiry Phase 1 that were specific to the brigade. Some firefighters we spoke to told us about the changes they had seen as a result. These included new equipment, such as breathing apparatus, drones and smoke hoods. Fire control staff we spoke to were trained in fire survival guidance (FSG) with regular testing of FSG procedures. Firefighters and incident commanders we spoke to were well trained to deal with fires in tall buildings, understood the FSG app (described earlier) and had taken part in high-rise exercises. We were impressed with the FSG app.

At this type of incident, a fire and rescue service would receive a high volume of simultaneous fire calls. We found the system in place in the brigade is robust enough to receive and manage this volume of calls. Staff in the emergency control room, at the incident and in assisting control rooms can share, view and update the actions that result from the individual fire calls.

The brigade works well with other fire and rescue services

The brigade supports other fire and rescue services responding to emergency incidents. Brigade figures show that that, for the year 2023/24, the brigade attended 633 mutual assistance incidents. This included 155 special service calls and 142 primary fires. (A special service call is a non-fire incident, for example a road traffic collision, a water rescue, a rescue from height or an animal rescue.) It is intraoperable with these services and can form part of a multi-agency response. Eighty percent (510 out of 634) of staff who responded to our survey agreed that the brigade was intraoperable with neighbouring services.

The brigade has a number of resources, such as a special entry and recovery team and high-volume pumps, that it can deploy to support other services anywhere in the country with major incident response. We found staff we spoke to about this were clear on how to deploy these resources.

The number of cross-border exercises has increased

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure cross-border risks are made known to crews. It should run a programme of over-the-border exercises, passing on the lessons learned from these exercises. The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has a comprehensive cross-border exercise plan with neighbouring fire and rescue services, helping them work together effectively to keep the public safe. The plan includes the risks of major events at which the brigade could foreseeably give support or ask for help from neighbouring services. For example, Exercise Felix Fort took place on 25 February 2024. This was an MTA exercise involving multi-agency and cross-border resources at a shopping centre in Bromley. The brigade used over 150 role players and Kent and Surrey's police armed response vehicles. It uses feedback from exercises such as this to inform risk information and brigade plans. We were encouraged to see the plan also records the subject of the training, who was involved and learning outcomes.

The brigade has increased the number of cross-border exercises it does. For each of the years 2021/22 and 2022/23, the brigade completed 30 training exercises. This is an increase from nine exercises in 2020/21.

Incident commanders are trained in Joint Emergency Services Interoperability Principles

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it is well prepared to form part of a multi-agency response to an incident, and all relevant staff know how to apply Joint Emergency Services Interoperability Principles (JESIP). The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The incident commanders we interviewed had been trained in and were familiar with JESIP. Some of this training had taken place with partners such as the London Ambulance Service.

The brigade could give us strong evidence that it consistently follows these principles. This includes:

- multi-agency exercise plans such as for an MTA
- showing understanding of the Joint Decision Model
- including JESIP in incident commander training.

We sampled a range of debriefs the brigade had carried out after multi-agency incidents and/or exercises. We were encouraged to find that the brigade is identifying any problems it has with applying JESIP and taking appropriate, prompt action with other emergency services.

There are good emergency response arrangements with partners

The brigade has good arrangements in place to respond to emergencies with its partners that make up the London Resilience Forum (LRF). The brigade is a valued partner, and the brigade's deputy commissioner is deputy chair of the forum. The brigade is represented at tactical level on the LRF partnership board and on each of the six LRF working groups.

The brigade takes part in regular training events with other members of the LRF and uses the learning to develop planning assumptions about responding to major and multi-agency incidents. For example, the brigade is part of planning and exercises for heatwaves and major events such as the Notting Hill Carnival and Pride in London. It works with other partners including the Metropolitan Police Service as part of the London strategic partnership group, which meets regularly to prepare for events.

The brigade contributes to, and makes use of, national learning

The brigade makes sure it knows about updates to national operational learning from other fire and rescue services and joint organisational learning from other organisations, such as the police service and ambulance trusts. It uses this learning to inform planning assumptions that it makes with partner organisations. The brigade has a single point of contact for national operational learning and joint organisational learning, and communicates learning through newsletters such as operational newsflashes.

An example of learning that the brigade contributed to national operational learning relates to a fire in warehouses on an industrial estate. Five firefighters came into contact with fire water run-off which contained significant quantities of an alkaline that was stored at the warehouses, causing injuries. This resulted in a review of responder decontamination arrangements and attendance at warehouse fires.

Making best use of resources

Good

London Fire Brigade is good at making best use of its resources.

Fire and rescue services should manage their resources properly and appropriately, aligning them with their risks and statutory responsibilities. Services should make best possible use of resources to achieve the best results for the public.

The brigade's revenue budget for 2024/25 is £495.1 million. This is a 6 percent increase from the previous financial year.

Innovative practice

Improved use of technology enables the efficient monitoring of firefighter productivity

The fire station performance dashboard enables the brigade to monitor the productivity of staff at fire stations against a range of performance measures. These include:

- percentage of time spent on home fire safety visits and protection work;
- percentage of time spent on training; and
- average arrival time of first fire engine.

The brigade reports on firefighter productivity in its community risk management plan, 'Your London Fire Brigade'.

This had led to the brigade being able to improve firefighter productivity.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

Resourcing plans are consistent with CRMP objectives

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it reviews how it allocates its resources to activities, based on the risks set out in the London Safety Plan. In our 2022 inspection, we also identified as an additional area for improvement that the brigade needs to show a clear rationale for the resources allocated between prevention, protection and response activities. This should reflect, and be consistent with, the risks and priorities set out in its CRMP. The brigade has made good progress and so both areas for improvement are closed.

The brigade's financial and workforce plans, including allocating resources to prevention, protection and response, are consistent with the risks and priorities it has identified in its CRMP. For example, this plan reflects a mayoral priority not to reduce numbers of firefighters, fire engines and fire stations. The brigade told us that this was to maintain the response to large-scale incidents that could happen in London. We found that priorities identified in the CRMP were clearly linked to departmental strategies, borough plans and station plans.

The brigade is well informed about the resources it needs. It has developed a workforce plan which assesses the skills needed to meet the risks identified in its CRMP. For example, the plan identifies that the brigade doesn't have enough protection inspection officers. So the brigade has set up its own fire safety training academy and introduced pay enhancements to attract and retain staff in this area.

It builds its plans on sound scenarios. They help make sure the brigade is sustainable and are underpinned by financial controls that reduce the risk of misusing public money. For example, proposed capital projects are subject to assessment of their affordability, cost-effectiveness and support to CRMP priorities.

The brigade has yet to evaluate its mix of crewing and duty systems and is committed to a staged approach in reviewing its operational response model. It continues to focus on using its operational resources more efficiently, for example by using its operational staff better to cover shortfalls in crewing and relying less on overtime.

Good progress has been made in managing productivity and performance

We were pleased to see that the brigade's arrangements for managing performance clearly link resource use to its strategic priorities. The brigade has 31 key performance indicators to measure how it is performing against its CRMP. For example, the target for prevention is that 60 percent of all HFSVs should be completed on high-risk cases.

The brigade understands how it uses its wholetime firefighters. It collects data on how they spend their time across day and night shifts. We were impressed by the fire station performance dashboard. This enables operational staff – and managers – to see their performance. For example, day-shift firefighters have a target to spend 12 percent of their time on prevention activity and 3 percent of their time on protection activity. Operational staff we spoke to understood the productivity measures and were well aware of how they were monitored. The brigade told us it has plans to develop productivity targets for night shifts once day-shift productivity has been maximised.

The brigade is taking steps to make sure the workforce's time is as productive as possible. This includes putting in place new ways of working. For example, the brigade makes use of flexible working for staff. Managers at stations can adjust their work during the day to meet demand. And the brigade told us some operational staff can work different shift patterns such as days only or a variety of different shifts.

Collaboration has improved

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it effectively monitors, reviews and evaluates the benefits and outcomes of any contractual arrangements, collaboration or other improvement projects. We were encouraged to see the improvements the brigade has made and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were pleased to see the brigade meets its statutory duty to collaborate. It routinely considers opportunities to collaborate with other emergency responders. The brigade has established links with the National Police Air Service to make sure the brigade can view real-time images taken by police helicopters of fires in tall buildings. The brigade has also collaborated internationally in the development of the National Inter-agency Liaison Officer programme for overseas partners, including NATO.

Collaborative work is aligned to the priorities and commitments in the brigade's CRMP. For example, the brigade is part of the Greater London Authority procurement board and IT group. Collaborations with the Greater London Authority include contracts for temporary labour and recruitment.

The brigade comprehensively monitors, reviews and evaluates the benefits and results of its collaborations. The brigade manages proposed projects through business case submission to make sure there are stronger links between resourcing and CRMP priorities. Notable results include collaboration between the brigade and the Metropolitan Police Service in sharing the same mobile phone provider. The brigade told us this has saved £200,000 per year. The actual costs of each collaborative procurement are monitored by the brigade against estimated costs.

Robust and well-tested business continuity plans are in place

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it has good business continuity arrangements in place across the whole organisation. And that these are understood by all staff and take account of all foreseeable threats and risks. We were encouraged to see the improvements the brigade has made so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has good continuity arrangements in place for areas in which it considers threats and risks to be high. It regularly reviews and tests these threats and risks so that staff know the arrangements and their associated responsibilities. For example, the brigade has assessed the resource it needs to manage risk in the event of industrial action by brigade staff. It has a contract with an external company to provide sufficient cover. We were encouraged to find good awareness of station business continuity plans among nearly all staff we spoke to.

The brigade has made progress in achieving financial savings and efficiencies

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure that it is taking action to reduce non-pay costs and can show how it is achieving value for money. We were pleased to see the improvements the brigade has made and so the area for improvement is closed.

There are regular reviews to consider all the brigade's expenditure, including its non-pay costs. And this scrutiny makes sure the brigade gets value for money. For example, the brigade's investment and finance board carries out in-depth analysis to understand the cost of services and how it is spending its money. IT expenditure totalling £20 million was reviewed by the board to examine where the money was being spent and why.

The brigade is taking steps to make sure it achieves efficiency gains through sound financial management and best working practices. It is doing this in important areas such as estate, fleet and procurement. For example, the brigade told us it has made a £1.7 million saving by improving the management of property and fleet supplier contracts through negotiation.

The brigade has made savings and efficiencies, which haven't affected its operational performance and the service it gives the public. Data from 2022/23 shows pre-arranged overtime per head of workforce was £1,704.84 while the overall England rate was £1,464.15. In response, the brigade has carried out work to reduce overtime spending. It told us that, for 2023/24, overspend on pre-arranged overtime has decreased from £12 million to around £6 million. The brigade has achieved this decrease by using its firefighters better to crew shortfalls and by reducing operational staff sickness. However, it is still overspending on its overtime and should continue its work to reduce this.

The brigade's MTA capability has come at additional cost

We found the brigade provides an effective response to MTAs. However, the brigade has a skills allowance, which is equivalent to 2 percent of base pay, to compensate firefighters for carrying out fire and rescue duties in an MTA. This is in effect paying firefighters twice for an essential service. As a result, we are yet to be satisfied that this is an efficient use of public money.

We recognise the challenges the brigade has faced to reach a position where it can provide an effective MTA response, but this comes at an added cost.

Making the fire and rescue service affordable now and in the future

Good

London Fire Brigade is good at making the service affordable now and in the future.

Fire and rescue services should continuously look for ways to improve their effectiveness and efficiency. This includes transforming how they work and improving their value for money. Services should have robust spending plans that reflect future financial challenges and efficiency opportunities, and they should invest in better services for the public.

Area for improvement

The brigade needs to assure itself that it continues to maximise opportunities to improve workforce productivity and develop future capacity through use of innovation, including the use of technology.

Innovative practice

Sustainability plans and investment in technology are reducing the brigade's carbon emissions

The brigade has committed £9.5 million of funding to reduce emissions and support more carbon-neutral fire stations. So far, the brigade has:

- installed solar electrical generation at 71 stations;
- installed heat pumps at 19 stations;
- installed energy-efficient LED lighting in 85 percent of stations;
- developed its first carbon-zero station at Walthamstow;
- reduced fleet emissions by moving to 100 percent electric vehicle use for its officer cars; and
- installed 114 electric vehicle charging points.

Brigade figures show that when it started this work, it produced 10,991 tonnes of carbon dioxide during 2020/21. It has seen a steady fall over the last four years. For 2023/24, it produced 9,324 tonnes of carbon dioxide.

The brigade uses an online portal to efficiently and effectively manage property services and repairs

The brigade's property team developed a property portal. All staff can access it and, for example, request a repair or another property-related service through a series of easily accessible categories of work. The request is logged and goes directly to contractors for action.

Staff can see communications, timelines and outcomes of all repairs.
Sixty percent of all repairs and services are logged through the portal.

The property team extracts portal data to assess the most common repairs and monitor contractors' performance.

The team's work resulted in the brigade winning a national award for facilities management in 2022.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

Future financial challenges are understood

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it has strong enough plans in place to address financial challenges beyond 2023 and secure an affordable way of managing fire and other risks. We were encouraged to see the improvements the brigade has made and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has developed a sound understanding of future financial challenges.
It plans to mitigate its main financial risks. For example, the brigade will use its budget flexibility reserve to cover the effect of a higher-than-budgeted pay award in 2024/25 and help balance the 2024/25 revenue budget.

The underpinning assumptions are relatively robust, realistic and prudent.
Key financial risks are identified and recorded on the brigade's risk register.
The brigade takes account of the wider external environment and some scenario planning for future spending reductions. These include pay inflation, equipment costs and uncertainty about the levels of future funding from the Mayor of London and the UK Government.

We were pleased to see that the brigade has identified savings and investment opportunities to improve the service to the public or generate further savings. The brigade's 2024/25 revenue budget includes around £16.3 million of identified savings. It has carried out efficiency reviews to identify these savings and will also maintain its vacancy margins. (A vacancy margin is the number of posts that are budgeted for but not filled throughout the year.) While the brigade is investing in training firefighters in modern firefighting tactics, it is planned that this will no longer be funded from reserves in 2026/27. The brigade expects this to be a future spending pressure on its revenue budget. It therefore plans to continue its efficiency reviews to develop other savings options to avoid a future budget deficit.

Over the years 2024/25 to 2027/28, there will also be significant capital investment of £115.9 million in the brigade's estate.

Reserves are well managed

The brigade has a sensible and sustainable plan for using its reserves. The brigade has set the level for its general reserve at 3.5 percent (£17 million) of net revenue budget. It has carried out a risk assessment of the adequacy of its general reserve for 2024/25 as part of its budget-setting process.

The brigade carries out an annual review of its earmarked reserves (money set aside for a specific purpose). Through the review process, the brigade identified £4.5 million of earmarked reserves that were no longer needed. These have been released to fund programmes of work to support CRMP priorities.

The brigade is using reserves to improve its long-term effectiveness. For example, it is using £20.7 million from the fire safety improvement reserve to meet modern firefighting and training requirements in 2024/25 and 2025/26.

Fleet and estate strategies are clearly linked to the brigade's CRMP

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure that it develops fleet and estate management programmes that are linked to the new CRMP. Also, that it understands the impact future changes to those programmes may have on its service to the public. The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were impressed to find comprehensive strategies for estate and fleet that were clearly linked to the brigade's CRMP. For example, the estate strategy accounts for long-term projects such as better electrical infrastructure and zero-carbon initiatives. However, the brigade has yet to secure funding to fully support these plans.

We were pleased with the progress of the 'Privacy for All' programme. This five-year programme, ending in 2027, is to update washroom and resting facilities across fire stations. At the time of our inspection, 24 stations had been completed, with a target to complete a further 25 by the end of 2024.

Both the estate and the fleet strategies exploit opportunities to improve efficiency and effectiveness. For example, the brigade has been using telematics on its vehicles and other data to understand how efficiently its fleet is used. This data includes how long engines are unavailable due to planned maintenance and accidents. The brigade measures this in terms of cost. It told us the cost over a year was shown to be £800,000.

The brigade regularly reviews these strategies so that it can properly assess the effect any changes in estate and fleet provision, or future innovation, have on risk.

IT systems have been improved, but some still need to be updated

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade needs to assure itself that it is maximising opportunities to improve workforce productivity and develop future capacity through the use of innovation, including the use of technology.

We were encouraged to find the brigade is actively considering how changes in technology and future innovation may affect risk. It also seeks to exploit opportunities to improve efficiency and effectiveness presented by changes in technology. For example, we were impressed by the brigade's online property portal, described earlier. We also found the brigade is using an app to make sure fire survival guidance is communicated and updated simultaneously between fire control and the scene of an incident. And it uses an app that enables members of the public to share footage of an incident through their mobile phone. This helps the brigade to decide on the most effective response.

However, in our last inspection we identified that some systems didn't support productive working and needed to be replaced. During this inspection, we found some of these systems still in place. For example, IT systems which support finance and purchasing had yet to be replaced. And a paper-based HFSV system was still being used because the brigade's electronic HFSV app wasn't in full use across the brigade. The brigade told us that due to competing demands on IT resources, it has had to prioritise other IT work. But the brigade plans to improve these systems.

While we recognise the progress the brigade has made, there is still more to do, and so the area for improvement remains.

The brigade has improved its capacity to manage change

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it has the right skills and capacity in place to successfully manage change across the organisation. We are satisfied with the progress made and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has improved its capacity and capability to achieve sustainable transformation, and it routinely seeks opportunities to work with others to improve efficiency and provide better services in the future. For any proposed project, a business case has to be submitted. This is then prioritised using a framework to assess which project will produce the best benefits.

We were pleased to find the brigade has established a portfolio team with programme and project managers who support major change plans. Team members measure the benefits of these plans against such criteria as reduction in spend, improvement in value and non-financial benefits.

However, only 48 percent (526 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey agreed that change is managed well by the brigade. This is despite 74 percent (814 out of 1,094) of respondents stating the brigade keeps them informed about matters that affect them.

The brigade should continue to build its capability to meet the demands of its change plans.

The brigade plans to further increase the income it generates

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure that it takes full advantage of opportunities to secure external funding and generate income to improve services and increase efficiency. The brigade has made sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade actively considers and exploits opportunities to generate extra income. For example, the brigade generates £5.7 million from tenants across its estate and telecoms masts fixed to brigade premises. And it generates £40 million of income through the Metropolitan Fire Brigade Act. This is a levy that insurance companies pay for the service provided by the brigade.

We found the brigade plans to further increase income as part of its efficiency plan for 2024/25. This includes offering a hydrant inspection service to private landlords.

Where appropriate, it has secured external funding to invest in improvements to the service it gives the public. For example, it obtained £3.5 million of external funding to support its plans to reduce carbon emissions across the brigade.

Promoting the right values and culture

Adequate

London Fire Brigade is adequate at promoting the right values and culture.

Fire and rescue services should have positive and inclusive cultures, modelled by the behaviours of their senior leaders. Services should promote health and safety effectively, and staff should have access to a range of well-being support that can be tailored to their individual needs.

Areas for improvement

The brigade should carry out a review of brigade processes designed to deal with behaviour such as bullying and discrimination, and implement improvements that build trust and confidence among staff.

The brigade should monitor secondary contracts to make sure working hours aren't exceeded.

Promising practice

The brigade has effective plans that are improving culture

The brigade began a transformation of its culture by producing a comprehensive action plan. The plan supported a structured approach to cultural change with robust governance arrangements to monitor its progress. A dedicated programme team was responsible for the progress of the actions.

As the brigade implemented the plan, staff were involved in developing brigade values. And members of the brigade's community forum were asked for their views. The brigade set up a dedicated professional standards unit to investigate and deal with complaints of bullying, harassment and discrimination.

As a result, the brigade is successfully transforming its culture. Its independent advisory panel and community forum provide ongoing scrutiny of the cultural change work.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

In our 2022 inspection, we found the brigade needed to do more to improve the culture in the brigade. We were concerned about behaviours that weren't in line with brigade values, including discrimination and bullying. We recommended that the brigade put plans in place to:

- communicate brigade values to staff effectively, making sure that they understand and can demonstrate acceptable behaviours at all times;
- ensure it communicates with managers at all levels, so they demonstrate brigade values through their positive workplace behaviours and are trained to identify and deal with non-compliance; and
- undertake a review of brigade processes designed to deal with behaviour such as bullying and discrimination and implement improvements that build trust and confidence among staff.

We re-inspected the brigade in February 2024 to specifically consider progress against this cause of concern. We published our findings in March 2024. We found the brigade had made enough progress against the first two recommendations, which were closed.

We recognised the progress the brigade had made against the third recommendation: the review of processes that deal with behaviour such as bullying and discrimination. However, at the time of the revisit some of this work was newly in place or hadn't been completed. As a result, we kept our third recommendation in place and decided to assess progress as part of this inspection.

In this inspection, we found the brigade has continued to make good progress against the third recommendation.

We found a clear and sustained commitment to improve how the brigade manages allegations and incidents of bullying, harassment and discrimination. The brigade told us that, since its introduction in January 2024, the professional standards unit (PSU) had opened 200 cases. Most staff we spoke to about the PSU were positive about it. However, a few staff told us that cases took too long to investigate or weren't being dealt with consistently. The brigade told us it is recruiting an additional eight staff into the PSU to meet demand.

The brigade is making good progress in its staff vetting programme. DBS checks that result in a positive disclosure are risk assessed and sent to the PSU for further action. The brigade told us that it had allocated additional staff to the programme to meet its target of a third of all brigade staff being vetted by February 2025.

We were pleased to find the brigade's work to improve its HR service was nearly complete. This work includes combining areas such as counselling and well-being services to be more efficient. It also includes introducing an HR helpdesk to help resolve issues more quickly. While this is an area where the brigade still needs to improve, our level of concern has decreased due to the amount of progress it has made against its plan and the ongoing work to complete it. We will continue to assess this work from now on.

As a result of the progress the brigade has made against the cause of concern's third recommendation, we now consider this to be completed. This means that the brigade has completed all the recommendations associated with the cause of concern and so it is closed.

Values are well understood, but not all behaviour meets the standards expected

The brigade has taken clear action to improve its culture. For example, the brigade has put significant effort into developing leadership skills among middle managers and improving their ability to deal with bad workplace behaviour. And it has improved the data available to managers to help identify cultural issues at a local level. The brigade has completed a review of discipline and grievance policies.

The brigade has developed a clearly defined set of values. We found they are linked to brigade plans and processes. For example, the values form part of the brigade's promotion and recruitment processes. The brigade actively involved staff in the development of its values. For example, 1,065 staff gave feedback on the values as part of the brigade's 'leading culture' discussions.

The brigade has made significant efforts to effectively communicate the new values to staff. Senior leaders held face-to-face briefings about the values with brigade managers and leaders. We saw evidence of values being included in departmental, borough and station plans. And values workshops are helping staff understand what the values mean to them. Nearly all the staff we spoke to during our inspection were aware of the values and understood them: 97 percent (1,064 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey said they were aware of the brigade values.

We were encouraged that some staff told us that senior leaders display brigade values. Staff also gave us examples of senior leaders personally praising crews for their work.

However, although the brigade has improved its culture, it is an area that needs to continue to improve.

The brigade has more work to do to make sure that all leaders consistently display the values. A total of 37 percent (389 out of 1,064) of staff who responded to our survey didn't agree that senior leaders in the brigade model and maintain the values expected.

Some behaviours we saw or were told about didn't meet the standards expected. For example, a few staff told us that there is still more to do to address views that are misogynist or racist. We saw offensive graffiti on a cubicle wall at one station we visited.

Some staff we spoke to felt empowered and willing to challenge poor behaviour when they come across it. However, the brigade is aware it has more work to do in this area to make sure all staff feel this way.

There is good support for staff well-being

The brigade continues to have well-understood and effective well-being policies in place, which are available to staff. The brigade has a well-being strategy that details its approach to well-being.

A range of well-being support is available to support both physical and mental health. For example, counselling is available following traumatic incidents, and well-being support is available through the Fire Fighters Charity. We were encouraged to be told that, since our last inspection, the brigade has increased the number of mental health first-aiders from 80 to 343. Ninety-one percent (1,000 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey said they feel able to access services to support their mental well-being.

There is good provision to promote staff well-being. This includes maternity well-being spaces and menopause support. And the brigade's fitness advisory team helps those with musculoskeletal issues back into the workplace. Nearly all staff reported that they understand and have confidence in the well-being support processes available.

The brigade takes action on health and safety issues

The brigade continues to have effective and well-understood health and safety policies and procedures in place. These are readily available, and the brigade promotes them effectively to all staff. It also communicates health and safety information through its 'Operational Newsletter'.

Ninety-four percent (1,028 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey agreed that they understand the policies and procedures. Ninety-three percent (1,017 out of 1,094) agreed that procedures for reporting all accidents, near misses and dangerous occurrences are clear. Eighty-five percent (925 out of 1,094) were satisfied that their personal safety and welfare are treated seriously.

The brigade monitors health and safety performance against key performance indicators. For the year 2022/23, there were 71 RIDDOR reports over 7 days. (RIDDOR stands for Reporting of Injuries, Diseases and Dangerous Occurrences

Regulations.) The brigade monitors such injuries for common themes. For example, it identified that some ankle injuries were occurring while staff were dismounting a fire engine. As a result, the brigade is reviewing its information and training on dismounting a fire engine.

In our 2022 inspection, we found that there was no central storage for locally created risk assessments for areas such as policies or training. We found this is still the case. The brigade should make sure it stores risk assessments in a location that is easy to access.

During our inspection, some staff expressed health and safety concerns about new breathing apparatus sets that are in use. The brigade told us that it is taking formal action against the supplier with union and legal support. It has also approached the Health and Safety Executive directly about the issue.

The brigade recognises it needs to improve the health and safety training it gives its staff. For example, a gap has been identified at management level regarding managing health and safety in stations and leading by example on health and safety. The brigade plans to address this through a 'Leading Safety' course aimed at operational middle managers.

We were encouraged to find the brigade has a plan to carry out a regular programme of fitness testing for its operational staff. However, fitness testing only started on 1 July 2024. The brigade told us the delay was due to union negotiations about the programme. We look forward to seeing how it progresses.

The brigade isn't effectively using systems to monitor secondary employment hours

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should monitor secondary contracts to make sure working hours aren't exceeded.

We were encouraged to find the brigade has an outside employment policy, which requires staff to get approval to take on secondary employment. The brigade has developed an outside employment app for staff to record the hours they work.

However, we found limited assurance that the policy is being followed and that action is being taken to consistently record and monitor individual hours. Data shows that, as of 31 March 2023, 41.3 percent of the brigade's wholetime firefighters had external secondary employment. The brigade told us that, between January and April 2024, a majority of the staff required to declare their external working hours weren't doing so (491 out of 856).

Some staff we spoke to about this said they weren't engaging with the secondary employment process. Reasons given included that processes to record secondary employment were too difficult to use, or staff felt that what they did outside the brigade wasn't its business.

We recognise that some progress has been made, but there is more to do, so the area for improvement remains.

Management of short-term absence is improving

We found clear processes in place to manage absences for all staff. The brigade has a comprehensive attendance management policy that sets out staff's responsibility for reporting absence.

The brigade monitors sickness trends through its people dashboard. For example, it uses this to identify those who are on long-term sickness who may be able to carry out other duties in the brigade. Staff can also work with the brigade's fitness advisory team to complete a functional rehabilitation programme. This includes maternity and menopause-specific training, to support individuals in returning to the workplace.

In 2022/23, the average number of days not worked per firefighter due to short-term sickness decreased by 4.2 percent compared to 2021/22. However, long-term sickness has increased. In 2022/23, the average number of days not worked per firefighter due to long-term sickness increased by 2.3 percent compared to 2021/22.

The brigade told us it had trained 1,812 of its managers on recognising and managing stress, anxiety and depression. However, not all managers we spoke to could recall having this training or any training on absence management. The brigade should make sure all managers are trained to manage staff absence.

Getting the right people with the right skills

Adequate

London Fire Brigade is adequate at getting the right people with the right skills.

Fire and rescue services should have a workforce plan in place that is linked to their community risk management plans. It should set out their current and future skills requirements and address capability gaps. This should be supplemented by a culture of continuous improvement, including appropriate learning and development throughout the service.

Area for improvement

The brigade needs to train all staff properly for their roles, including developing all levels of leadership and management competence.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

Workforce needs are understood through effective planning

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure its workforce plan takes full account of the necessary skills and capabilities to deliver its integrated risk management plan (now known as a CRMP) and the London Safety Plan. The brigade has made sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were pleased to find the brigade has a workforce strategy and plan in place. This makes sure skills and capabilities align with what it needs to effectively carry out its CRMP. It has identified where it has enough skills and resource. Where there are gaps, the brigade knows how long they will take to close. For example, the brigade found that its external training provider couldn't train all the drivers it needs. The brigade has recruited a driving instructor to increase training capacity in this area.

Succession planning is improving

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should review its succession planning to make sure that it has effective arrangements in place to manage staff turnover while continuing to provide its core service to the public. We found the brigade has made sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

Workforce and succession planning are subject to consistent scrutiny in the form of regular meetings to discuss requirements. The brigade monitors skills and resource levels through its establishment board. We found the workforce and training plan accounts for succession planning by identifying current and future skills requirements.

The brigade acknowledges there is still more work to do on skills and succession planning outside its core functions. For example, succession plans for skills such as IT and finance need further development.

The brigade knows it doesn't have enough inspecting officers among its protection staff. It has set up its own training academy to increase the number of qualified protection staff.

Overtime spend has decreased

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade needs to review its reliance on overtime and consider whether there are more effective ways to provide its core service.

We found that the brigade has significantly reduced its overtime spend. For example, the brigade has improved how it uses skills and resources to crew fire engines better. The brigade has made sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

Work continues to make sure staff receive sufficient training for their roles

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade needs to train all staff properly for their roles, including developing all levels of leadership and management competence.

The brigade's training plan makes sure operational staff can maintain competence and capability effectively. One of the plan's key commitments is to continue the brigade's leadership training programme for both operational and support staff at different levels.

However, some areas of training need to be improved. For example, we found that some e-learning training packages for operational staff were out of date. And other than apprentice firefighters and new recruits, operational staff we spoke to couldn't recall having had training in how to collect site-specific risk information. (This is information about the risks at specific sites, such as high-rise buildings, fuel storage facilities and hospitals, that may affect firefighting or the community.) And some staff we spoke to about safeguarding training felt it could be better.

The brigade has identified that training all staff properly for their roles, including developing leadership and management competence at all levels, is an extensive programme of work. While progress continues, the area for improvement will remain in place.

Risk-critical skills are up to date

We found the brigade monitors operational staff competence through practical and e-learning training as part of its Development and Maintenance of Operational Professionalism programme. Managers monitor the competence of their operational staff.

As part of our inspection, we sampled a range of training records for operational staff. We were pleased to find risk-critical competencies such as breathing apparatus, driving and incident command were in date.

We found the brigade doesn't have access to all training information in one place. For example, training records for fire control are stored on a separate system. And the training team can't access station diaries to monitor progress of all training. The brigade should make sure it has full oversight of all training and its progress.

Development opportunities are limited for some staff

The brigade is committed to providing learning and development for its staff. For example, its training plan lists training of leaders as one of its key commitments.

However, 35 percent (386 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey disagreed that they were able to access the right learning and development opportunities when they need to. Some brigade staff we spoke to who weren't in operational roles didn't feel they were offered the same training opportunities as operational staff or were able to access the right learning and development opportunities. They felt that progression depended on someone more senior leaving.

We found some of the brigade's e-learning wasn't up to date.

The brigade should make sure that learning and development opportunities are available for all staff groups.

Ensuring fairness and promoting diversity

Adequate

London Fire Brigade is adequate at ensuring fairness and promoting diversity.

Creating a more representative workforce gives fire and rescue services huge benefits. These include greater access to talent and different ways of thinking. It also helps them better understand and engage with local communities. Each service should make sure staff throughout the organisation firmly understand and show a commitment to equality, diversity and inclusion. This includes successfully taking steps to remove inequality and making progress to improve fairness, diversity and inclusion at all levels of the service. It should proactively seek and respond to feedback from staff and make sure any action it takes is meaningful.

Areas for improvement

The brigade should identify and overcome barriers to equal opportunity, so its workforce better represents its community. This includes making sure staff understand the value of positive action and having a diverse workforce.

The brigade should make sure the processes it has put in place to deal with staff grievances and behaviour such as bullying or harassment improve trust and confidence among staff.

Promising practice

A professional standards unit upholds and monitors standards of behaviour in the brigade

The professional standards unit acts as a centre of expertise and carries out overall monitoring of conduct in the brigade. It leads investigations into discipline and grievance issues including bullying, harassment and discrimination. It also provides advice and support.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

The brigade needs to continue to build confidence in its feedback systems

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it takes timely action in response to staff feedback or concerns and that actions are communicated to staff. The brigade has made sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has developed several ways to work with staff on issues and decisions that affect them. These include methods to build all-staff awareness of fairness and diversity, as well as targeted initiatives to identify matters that affect different staff groups. There are monthly all-staff briefings where staff can ask questions of the brigade leadership team. And newsletters such as 'Hotwire' and 'Your LFB' are emailed to staff.

The brigade has taken action to address matters staff have raised. For example, the brigade carried out a staff survey in 2023. This showed that some staff felt there was a lack of maternity support. The brigade revised its maternity policy and improved its approach to maternity leave. Staff received these actions positively. Furthermore, representative bodies and staff associations reported that the brigade works well with them.

However, the brigade should continue its work to build confidence in its feedback processes. Thirty-seven percent (400 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey didn't feel confident in the processes for providing feedback to all levels. And 40 percent (441 out of 1,094) of respondents didn't feel confident their ideas or suggestions would be listened to.

The brigade is improving how it tackles bullying, harassment and discrimination but needs to do more

The brigade provides a variety of ways for staff to raise concerns. We were impressed by the brigade's professional standards unit, which includes trained staff to give advice and proactively investigate grievance and discipline concerns.

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it has effective grievance procedures. It should identify and implement ways to improve staff confidence in the grievance process. While the brigade has made progress, the area for improvement remains.

We found the brigade has reviewed its processes for dealing with bullying and discrimination. We also found updated discipline and grievance policies to improve how matters are dealt with. The brigade is clear on its zero-tolerance approach to this behaviour. It has made training available to managers on grievance and discipline. However, some managers we spoke to couldn't recall having completed any training.

Not all staff are confident in the brigade's approach to tackling bullying, harassment, discrimination, grievances and disciplinary matters. In this inspection, 14 percent (154 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey said they had been subject to bullying or harassment in the last 12 months. And 13 percent (137 out of 1,094) of respondents said they had been subject to discrimination in the last 12 months. However, 39 percent (60 out of 154) of those who had been subject to bullying or harassment and 61 percent (83 out of 137) of those who had been subject to discrimination in the last 12 months hadn't reported the behaviour. The main reason for not reporting either type of behaviour was that they felt nothing would happen. The brigade would benefit from consistently using exit interviews when members of staff leave. This would help to understand if bullying, harassment or discrimination issues have caused someone to leave the brigade.

We were encouraged to find the brigade has continued to make significant progress to improve its HR service. For example, the brigade has been reviewing its HR policies and, as a result, has reduced the number of these policies from 114 to 69. Improvement of the service also involves bringing different teams together to make them more efficient, and providing additional training for HR staff.

The brigade doesn't use positive action effectively to recruit a more diverse workforce

There is an open, fair and honest recruitment process for staff or those wishing to work for the brigade. The brigade has an effective system to understand and remove the risk of disproportionality in recruitment processes. For example, for all roles at least one independent recruitment panel member is included. And hiring managers are briefed on equality, diversity and inclusion (EDI) expectations.

The brigade has put effort into developing its recruitment processes so that they are fair, and potential applicants can understand them. The brigade's community outreach team continues to organise events and campaigns aimed at underrepresented groups to encourage them to join the brigade. And fire control has been working with an external company to increase applications from men and people from minority groups. The brigade advertises recruitment opportunities both internally and externally.

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should identify and overcome barriers to equal opportunity, so its workforce better represents its community. This includes making sure staff understand the value of positive action and having a diverse workforce. There hasn't been enough progress and so the area for improvement remains.

There is still more to do to increase staff diversity although there has been a small increase in staff diversity at all levels of the organisation. In 2022/23, 28 percent of new joiners identified as being from an ethnic minority background. The proportion of firefighters who identified as being from an ethnic minority background has increased from 20.1 percent (890) in 2021/22 to 20.8 percent (917) in 2022/23. The proportion of firefighters who identified as a woman has increased from 9.2 percent (417) to 10 percent (456) over the same period.

For the whole workforce, in 2022/23, 23.2 percent identified as being from an ethnic minority background compared to 61.4 percent in their local population and 8.4 percent throughout all fire and rescue services. And 18.2 percent identified as a woman, compared to an average of 19.4 percent throughout all fire and rescue services.

The brigade acknowledges that it could use positive action more effectively to recruit a more diverse workforce. It told us targeted social media campaigns hadn't resulted in an increase in diverse candidates becoming firefighters and that it needs to evaluate and monitor positive action.

The brigade should continue to promote and use positive action effectively to recruit a more diverse workforce.

The brigade has a good approach to EDI

The brigade has improved its approach to equality, diversity and inclusion. It makes sure it can offer the right services to its communities and can support staff with protected characteristics. The brigade has a comprehensive EDI policy, which gives clear guidance for staff. We saw a range of information available to staff on the brigade's EDI intranet page.

There is good support for those with a protected characteristic through a range of staff networks, which staff spoke positively about. Menopause support is available for brigade staff, who can have up to 16 days off per year for menopause-related reasons. This doesn't count towards their absence figures.

Most staff we spoke to felt EDI had improved in the brigade. We were encouraged to hear some staff tell us they felt comfortable being themselves at work.

In our 2022 inspection, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it has robust processes in place to carry out equality impact assessments (EIAs) and review any actions agreed as a result. The brigade has made good progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

We were pleased to find an effective process in place to assess equality impact. We found clear guidance for staff completing EIAs, with a dedicated EIA section on the brigade's intranet. Staff can use an online tool to check if an EIA is required on any proposed policy or change to the way a service is carried out.

We found the brigade's EDI team provided good oversight. It reviews all EIAs and monitors progress and actions. We reviewed some EIAs that had been carried out. We found these had been completed to a good standard.

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure all fire stations have suitable facilities for women. The brigade is making sufficient progress and the area for improvement is closed.

There is a five-year programme to update washroom and resting facilities across fire stations to make them more inclusive for all staff. This is due to be completed by 2027. We were encouraged to find that, at the time of our inspection, this work had been completed at 24 stations. The brigade aims to complete a further 25 stations by the end of 2024.

Managing performance and developing leaders

Requires improvement

London Fire Brigade requires improvement at managing performance and developing leaders.

Fire and rescue services should have robust and meaningful performance management arrangements in place for their staff. All staff should be supported to meet their potential and there should be a focus on developing staff and improving diversity into leadership roles.

Areas for improvement

The brigade should make sure it has an effective system in place to review individual staff performance and development.

The brigade should put in place a system to actively manage all staff careers, with the aim of diversifying the pool of future and current leaders.

The brigade should put in place an open and fair process to identify, develop and support high-potential staff and aspiring leaders.

We set out our detailed findings below. These are the basis for our judgment of the brigade's performance in this area.

Main findings

The brigade doesn't use performance and development reviews effectively to manage individual performance

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure it has an effective system in place to review individual staff performance and development. There has been some progress, but the brigade still needs to do more and so the area for improvement remains.

We were encouraged to find that performance and development reviews (PDRs) are being completed. Most staff we spoke to said they have had a PDR. Eighty-five percent (930 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey said they have had a formal PDR or appraisal in the last 12 months, compared to 50 percent (659 out of 1,319) of respondents from our previous inspection.

However, some staff we spoke to felt that despite having a PDR, they didn't have any personal objectives set or didn't feel their PDR was worthwhile. Thirty-seven percent (342 out of 930) of respondents to our survey said they didn't find their PDR useful. Also, some managers told us that although there was guidance on how to complete PDRs, they hadn't received any training.

The brigade needs to make sure that PDRs are being completed to a good level of quality and are being used effectively to manage performance and development.

Promotion processes are fair

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should make sure that it selects, develops and promotes staff in an open, accessible and fair way, including for temporary promotions. The brigade has made sufficient progress and so the area for improvement is closed.

The brigade has put considerable effort into developing its promotion and progression processes for operational staff so that they are fair, and all staff can understand them. The brigade has produced guidance for operational staff to make sure they are eligible for promotion. Operational staff who want to apply for promotion discuss their suitability with their line manager, who will approve or decline the promotion request.

The brigade acknowledges that it still needs to develop progression paths for support staff. It is developing a recruitment and resourcing strategy, which will detail career paths for this staff group.

The brigade manages selection processes consistently. The small selection of promotion files we inspected was comprehensive. We saw evidence of decisions by promotion panel members recorded with candidate scoring against a clear set of criteria. And the brigade uses temporary promotions appropriately to fill short-term resourcing gaps.

The brigade advertises promotion opportunities internally and externally through platforms such as the National Fire Chiefs Council website and the Women in the Fire Service website. Reasonable adjustments are made so those who need them get support. However, it was disappointing that some staff told us that they think the promotion processes are unfair. Some staff described the processes as inconsistent and said that promotion was based on whether your face fitted. Fifty-three percent (577 out of 1,094) of respondents to our survey disagreed that promotion processes were fair. The brigade should continue to build confidence in its promotion processes.

The brigade needs to do more to diversify leadership

The brigade acknowledges that it has more to do to diversify leadership roles and that it could use positive action better to help achieve this.

It hasn't adopted the National Fire Chiefs Council's direct entry scheme. This would help to recruit from a wider pool of candidates with a broader set of backgrounds, skills and experiences.

However, it uses specialist recruitment agencies to find more diverse candidates for leadership roles. It also advertises vacancies internally and externally through organisations that represent minority groups, such as the Asian Fire Service Association.

Systems to develop leadership and high-potential staff need to be better

In our 2019 and 2022 inspections, we identified as an area for improvement that the brigade should put in place an open and fair process to identify, develop and support high-potential staff and aspiring leaders. There hasn't been sufficient progress, so the area for improvement remains.

The brigade needs to improve the way it actively manages the career pathways of staff, including those with specialist skills and those with potential for leadership roles.

The brigade workforce plan clearly identifies the operational skills it needs, and the brigade plans up to five years ahead for these. However, we noted that the training and skills plan didn't fully account for skills outside the prevention, protection and response functions. And the brigade needs to better manage systems that manage career pathways, especially for support staff and those with specific skills such as IT.

The brigade acknowledges that at the time of our inspection there was no process to identify and manage high-potential staff. It should consider putting in place more formal arrangements to identify and support members of staff to become senior leaders. This is a significant gap in its succession planning. The brigade told us it is looking to introduce a talent management process in 2026.

At the time of our inspection, the brigade had carried out a gap analysis concerning the implementation of the Fire Standards Board's Leading the Service and Leading and Developing People fire standards. We look forward to seeing how this work develops.

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